

Foreign Relations of Pakistan

Indo-Pak relations (Kashmir Issue)

Relations with Great Powers (US, China, Russia)

Pakistan and the Islamic World (Iran, Afghanistan, etc.)

The Kashmir Dispute: A Comprehensive Historical Background (1947–2026)

1. The Genesis of the Conflict (1947–1948)

The Kashmir issue emerged in 1947 during the Partition of the Subcontinent, when **Princely States** were given the right to accede to either Pakistan or India. Kashmir had a Muslim population of over 80%, which naturally leaned toward Pakistan. However, the Hindu Dogra Ruler, Maharaja Hari Singh, remained indecisive. When the Kashmiri people revolted against the Dogra rule and tribal lashkars arrived to support them, the Maharaja sought military aid from India. In exchange for help, India forced him to sign the **Instrument of Accession**, which Pakistan never recognized as it went against the will of the people. This led to the first Indo-Pak war in 1948, which ended through UN intervention with a promise that a **Plebiscite** (referendum) would be held in Kashmir.

2. UN Resolutions and the Shift to Bilateralism (1950s–1972)

Throughout the 1950s and 60s, the issue echoed on global forums. The United Nations passed several **Resolutions** demanding that Kashmiris be given the **Right of Self-determination**, but India delayed the process through various excuses. The 1965 war also centered on Kashmir (Operation Gibraltar), followed by the **Tashkent Declaration**. After the 1971 war, the **Simla Agreement (1972)** was signed, where both countries agreed to resolve all disputes, including Kashmir, through **Bilateral Talks**. This agreement strengthened India's attempts to limit the UN's role, though Pakistan maintains that international resolutions are still valid.

3. The Uprising and the Nuclear Flashpoint (1989–1999)

The year 1989 marked a new turning point when a powerful **armed struggle** and indigenous movement against Indian occupation began in the valley. India deployed hundreds of thousands of troops to suppress it, turning Kashmir into the world's largest **militarized zone**. The 1999 **Kargil War** brought the issue back to global headlines, especially since both nations had become nuclear powers. The international community feared that the Kashmir "bug" could trigger a **Nuclear War**. Despite some peace talks in the 2000s, a permanent solution remained elusive due to a deep **Trust Deficit**.

4. Revocation of Special Status (2019)

On August 5, 2019, India took a unilateral and massive step by revoking **Articles 370 and 35-A** of its constitution, ending the **Special Status** of Kashmir. The state was downgraded to a **Union Territory**, accompanied by a strict curfew and a total **internet blackout**. Pakistan declared this a violation of international law and suspended all **diplomatic ties**. This was a "system update" completely rejected by Kashmiris and Pakistan, as its primary goal was to change the **Demography** of the region and turn the Muslim majority into a minority.

5. The Digital Deadlock and Human Rights (2024–2026)

From 2024 to 2026, the situation indicates that Kashmir has evolved into a major **Human Rights** and digital surveillance issue. While India claims "normalcy," the Kashmiri leadership remains imprisoned, and despite the silence on the **Line of Control (LoC)**, internal resentment continues to grow. For Pakistan, Kashmir is its "**Jugular Vein**," while India calls it an "**Integral Part**." For a Computer Science student, this issue is like a "**Deadlock**" where two processes are stuck on the same resource (the land). Unless one party retreats or a **Third Party** (the international community) intervenes, this "system" cannot be restarted.

Key Vocabulary:

- ⇒ **Instrument of Accession:** The legal document signed by the Ruler to join a country.
 - ⇒ **Plebiscite:** A direct vote by the people to decide an important public question.
 - ⇒ **Bilateralism:** Direct negotiations between two parties without outside intervention.
 - ⇒ **Self-determination:** The process by which a country/people determines its own statehood.
 - ⇒ **Demography:** The study of population statistics (in this context, changing the religious ratio).
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Pakistan-US Relations (1947–2026): A Strategic Overview

1. The Era of Alliances (1947–1960s)

Immediately after independence, Pakistan opted for the American bloc instead of the Soviet Union, formally signaled by Prime Minister Liaquat Ali Khan's visit to the US in 1950. During the 1950s and 60s, Pakistan joined **defense pacts** like **SEATO** and **CENTO**. In exchange, the US provided massive **military and economic assistance**. During this period, Pakistan was considered the "most allied ally" of the US in Asia. However, during the 1965 and 1971 wars with India, the US maintained **neutrality** and suspended aid, leading Pakistani leadership to realize that the relationship was **transactional** rather than permanent.

2. The Afghan Jihad and the Pressler Amendment (1979–1990)

The Soviet invasion of Afghanistan in 1979 turned Pakistan back into a "**Frontline State**" for US interests. Under General Zia-ul-Haq, the US provided billions of dollars in weapons and funds to support the **Afghan Mujahideen**. While this bolstered Pakistan's **defense capabilities**, it also introduced "Kalashnikov culture" and extremism into society. As soon as the Soviets withdrew, the US invoked the **Pressler Amendment** in 1990, imposing harsh **sanctions** on Pakistan due to its **nuclear program**. This was perceived in Pakistan as a major strategic betrayal.

3. War on Terror and Post-9/11 Dynamics (2001–2011)

The 9/11 attacks shifted the global **geopolitical landscape** again. Under General Pervez Musharraf, Pakistan became a **Major Non-NATO Ally (MNNA)** in the **War on Terror**. While Pakistan received heavy funding through the **Coalition Support Fund (CSF)**, the era was marked by **drone strikes** and constant US demands to "**Do More.**" The relationship hit a breaking point in 2011 following the **Abbottabad Operation** and the **Salala check post attack**, which created a severe **trust deficit** between the two nations.

4. The Shift toward China and 2026 Reality (2021–2026)

Following the US withdrawal from Afghanistan in 2021, the relationship entered a fragile new phase. The US now attempts to view Pakistan through a lens of trade and **Climate Change** rather than just security. However, the growing **US-India strategic partnership** and Pakistan's deep ties with China (**CPEC**) remain significant obstacles to a balanced relationship. By 2026, the tie remains strictly **transactional**, with both nations prioritizing their own **national interests** while maintaining limited cooperation in specific sectors.

5. Why the "Ups and Downs"? (Strategic Analysis)

The fundamental cause of this volatility is the **clash of strategic goals**. The US has historically viewed Pakistan as a tool for specific objectives (containing the Soviets, fighting terrorism, or facilitating Afghan withdrawal). In contrast, Pakistan's priority has always been its **regional security** and the perceived threat from India. When their objectives align, the relationship peaks; when interests diverge, **bilateral ties** freeze. For a Computer Science student, this can be viewed as "**Conditional Logic**"—the strength of the connection depends entirely on the **Requirement** of the hour.

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Pakistan-Iran Relations (1947–2026): A Strategic Overview

1. The Era of Early Brotherhood (1947–1979)

The relationship between Pakistan and Iran began on an ideal note, as Iran was the first country to formally recognize Pakistan in 1947. During the 1950s and 60s, both nations were part of the **CENTO** defense pact, and Shah Mohammad Reza Pahlavi provided significant **military and political support** to Pakistan during the 1965 and 1971 wars with India. During this period, there were no major **strategic conflicts**, and Iran was considered Pakistan's most reliable and "all-weather" friend in the region.

2. The Paradigm Shift and Ideological Gap (1979–1990s)

The year 1979 brought a massive **Paradigm Shift** in bilateral ties. The Islamic Revolution occurred in Iran while General Zia-ul-Haq was in power in Pakistan. Iran's foreign policy became fiercely anti-US, while Pakistan became a key US ally due to the Afghan-Soviet war. This created an **Ideological Gap**, and the competition for influence in Afghanistan led to a **Proxy War** dynamic. For the first time, the national interests of both neighbors began to diverge significantly.

3. The Energy Dilemma: The IP Pipeline (2000s–2026)

In terms of economics, the most critical project has been the **Iran-Pakistan (IP) Gas Pipeline**, often called the "Peace Pipeline." However, Pakistan has been hesitant to complete its side of the project due to the fear of **International Sanctions** and external pressure from the US. This project is a prime example of how **Global Politics** can obstruct economic cooperation between two neighbors. By 2026, Pakistan is still trying to balance its need for energy with the risk of violating global **sanctions**.

4. Border Security and De-escalation (Recent Dynamics)

The shared border (the "Goldsmid Line") has recently become a center of tension. Both countries have accused each other of providing "safe havens" to **militant groups**, which peaked in the January 2024 **cross-border missile strikes**. Despite these incidents, the hallmark of this relationship is that both sides always revert to **Diplomacy**. Both nations realize that a conflict along a long, porous border is not in their interest, ensuring that **De-escalation** protocols remain active even during crises.

5. Regional Balancing and Future Outlook (2026)

The primary cause of the "ups and downs" in this relation is **Regional Balancing**. Pakistan's deep **strategic ties** with Saudi Arabia and Iran's growing economic links with India (such as the **Chabahar Port**) often create misunderstandings. However, geographical necessity dictates that they remain interdependent. In 2026, the relationship is defined by "Cooperation with Caution," where both seek to increase trade but remain wary of each other's **security sensitivities**.

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Pakistan-Afghanistan Relations (1947–2026): A Strategic Overview

1. Early Hostility and the Durand Line (1947–1970s)

The relationship between Pakistan and Afghanistan did not start on a friendly note. Afghanistan was the only country to oppose Pakistan's membership in the United Nations in 1947. The primary reason was the dispute over the **Durand Line** (the international border) and the **"Pashtunistan" issue**. During the 1950s and 60s, borders were closed multiple times, and **diplomatic ties** were often severed. While Afghanistan leaned toward the Soviet Union, Pakistan joined the Western bloc, creating a permanent state of **Strategic Tension**.

2. The Soviet Invasion and Strategic Depth (1979–1989)

The Soviet invasion of Afghanistan in 1979 completely changed the direction of bilateral ties. Pakistan hosted millions of **Afghan Refugees** and served as a "base camp" for the **Afghan Mujahideen**. During this era, the concept of **"Strategic Depth"** emerged, where Pakistan sought a friendly government in Kabul to avoid a two-front war with India. However, the post-Soviet withdrawal led to a brutal civil war, the fallout of which—including drugs and weapons—badly affected Pakistan's internal stability.

3. The War on Terror and Trust Deficit (2001–2021)

After the 9/11 attacks and the US-led invasion of Afghanistan, Pakistan found itself in a complex situation. While Pakistan was a US ally, the new governments in Kabul (under Hamid Karzai and Ashraf Ghani) expressed a deep **Trust Deficit** toward Islamabad. Both nations traded accusations of providing "safe havens" to terrorists. Pakistan's project of **Border Fencing** further increased tensions, as Afghanistan refused to recognize the fence as a formal international boundary.

4. The Return of the Taliban and Modern Friction (2021–2026)

With the Taliban's return to power in 2021, Pakistan hoped for a more stable and cooperative relationship. However, between 2024 and 2026, these hopes were challenged by the issue of the **TTP (Tehrik-i-Taliban Pakistan)** and frequent **border skirmishes**. Pakistan demands that Afghan soil not be used for cross-border terrorism, while the Afghan interim government asserts its **sovereignty**. Currently, the relationship is in a "highly sensitive" phase where trade continues, but security disagreements remain sharp.

5. Geographical Necessity vs. Political Bugs (2026)

The continuous volatility in this relationship stems from **Geographical and Political Constraints**. Afghanistan is a **landlocked** country that depends on Pakistani ports for trade, while Pakistan's access to **Central Asia** depends on peace in Afghanistan. For a Computer Science student, these relations are like a system with "shared databases" but "incompatible operating systems." Until the "bugs" of the Durand Line and cross-border militancy are fixed, the system will struggle to reach a **Stable State**.

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Pak-China Relation 1947-2026: A Strategic Overview

1. The Foundation of Trust (1951–1970s)

Pakistan and China established diplomatic ties in 1951. Pakistan was among the first countries to recognize the People's Republic of China. The 1963 **Boundary Agreement** solidified the relationship. During the 1965 and 1971 wars, China provided immense **military and moral support**. The construction of the **Karakoram Highway (KKH)** served as the first physical link between the two nations, often called the "Eighth Wonder of the World."

2. Strategic Depth and Global Diplomacy

Pakistan played a critical role as a bridge between the US and China in 1971, helping China end its global isolation. In return, China provided technical

assistance for Pakistan's **defense and nuclear programs**. This relationship is defined as an "**All-Weather Strategic Cooperative Partnership**," meaning it remains stable regardless of global political changes.

3. CPEC and the Digital Silk Road (2013–2026)

The launch of the **China-Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC)** in 2013 transformed the relationship into an economic powerhouse. For CS students, the **Digital Silk Road**—including the cross-border **fiber optic cable**—is a key highlight. It provides Pakistan with a high-speed data backbone and reduces dependence on other international routes. CPEC focuses on energy, infrastructure, and the **Gwadar Deep Water Port**.

4. Defense and Technological Synergy

The joint production of the **JF-17 Thunder** fighter jet is a masterpiece of shared engineering and technology transfer. By 2026, the cooperation has expanded into **Space Technology** and **Satellite Systems**. China remains Pakistan's largest trading partner and a primary source of **Foreign Direct Investment (FDI)**, providing crucial financial stability through loan rollovers during economic crises.

5. Convergence of Interests (2026 Outlook)

The primary reason for the stability of this relationship is the absolute **Convergence of Interests**. Both nations seek to balance regional power and maintain stability against shared rivals. While critics point to "**Debt Trap**" concerns, Pakistan views China as its most reliable partner for economic survival. In 2026, the focus has shifted toward **Artificial Intelligence (AI)**, cloud computing, and high-tech manufacturing.